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The Heald Matrix

WHY Business Owners Fail to Plan

The Framework Purpose

Two of the most common ways that people try to directly influence their lives is through behaviour modelled on **ASSERTION** or **WITHDRAWL** (the third is **DUTIFUL**)

In the business world, ASSERTION can look like someone is 'Focused and Driven' but (in time) can 'drop through the health levels' to make the same mindset appear 'Stubborn and Ignorant'.

WITHDRAWAL could appear (in a positive state) as being 'Considered and Prudent' but again (over time) that same mindset could allow them to appear 'Lazy and Aimless'.

In many cases, business owners are struggling to find clarity and determine purposeful actions that THEY BELIEVE CAN CHANGE THEIR FUTURE. Planning is a great way to help them find these meaningful actions but first, we need to help them recognise that their current coping mechanisms are not serving them well.

This is (most often) NOT something you can 'tell' somebody; it's better if they 'see themselves' falling from grace in order to decide to make a change in their world.

The Heald Matrix is a framework to help business owners 'See Themselves' avoiding business planning based on a combination of how they cope (with the world around them) and lack of knowledge on how to plan effectively. Once they EXPERIENCE how easily they can 'let go' of their current coping mechanism and gain CLARITY OF ACTION, they will be MUCH more agreeable to a future planning session with you.

The Heald Matrix

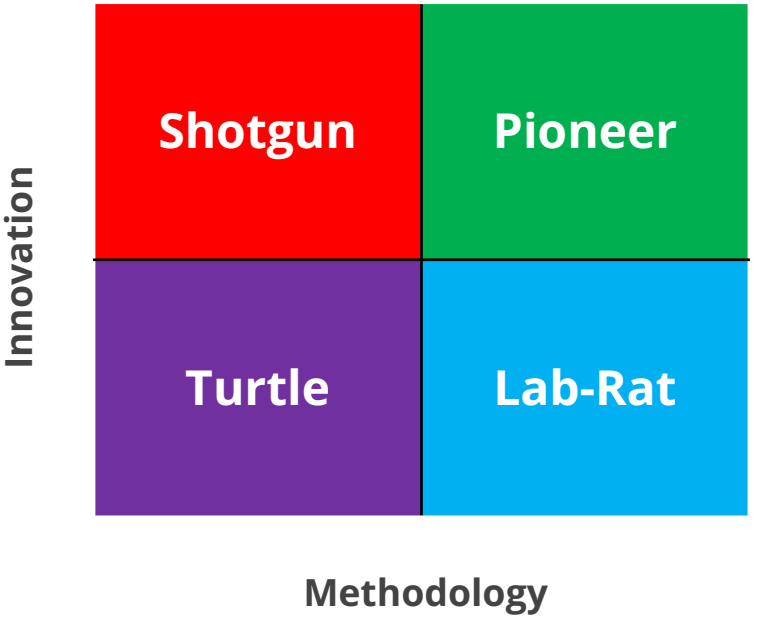
Descriptions:

Turtle: The same old thing the same old way. Supports this thinking by the "if it ain't broke, don't fix it" saying but forgets that "time and tide waits for no man…"

Shotgun: Shoot and hope; Creative but lacking data – flying by the seat of their pants – hope hides the fear. (Driven by emotional assessment) Like Edward Deming said, "Without data, you're just another person with an opinion…"

Lab-Rat: Stuck in the grips of fear & judgement; this fixation causes them to second guess themselves often, they forget that trial & error is a legitimate means of testing.

Pioneer: Recognises the need to discover new lands; combines gratitude for current means with excitement for what's new. Balances fresh ideas with sound process to achieve effective testing and deployment. Enjoys an indomitable spirit.



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Heald Matrix Reveal Order & Prompts

1. **Write the title: It creates intrigue, buys you time to collect your thoughts and focuses your and your client on the content to be discussed.**
2. **Draw the axis indices and label them; (Innovation/Creativity and Methodology/Process) remember to put 'high-low' or +/- to indicate the contrast. (High in creativity but low methodology for example)**
3. **Reveal 'Turtle' and discuss.**
4. **Reveal 'Shotgun' and discuss.**
5. **Reveal 'Lab-rat' and discuss.**
6. **Reveal 'Pioneer' and discuss.**

FACILITATION PROMPTS

1. **Where do you think you sit on the matrix?** (Increase their self relevance by sliding along the chosen box axis – "say when if I get to the point…")
2. **WHAT makes you say that?** (NEVER WHY – why is potentially inflammatory as it causes them to seek an internal point of cognition or thinking / therefore their thinking /theory is being challenged. WHAT causes them to seek something 'material' or an action – external to themselves, therefore less challenging)
3. You can write the word 'Evidence' on the board – you are genuinely looking to AFFIRM their position and find proof that they are correct in their assessment. If it appears that are incorrect you may suggest they have been 'a bit harsh on themselves' and give reasons for why they may be placed elsewhere. Remember, the TEMPLATE will challenge them (internally) so you don't need to be too confrontational. The point is to generate a positive feeling remember!
4. **Where would you like to be on the matrix in future?**
5. **IF you took one small baby step towards (desired position on matrix) WHAT might that step look like?** (using the word IF will reduce self judgement and improve creative responses, one small baby step – what will it look like causes the mind to imagine an ACTION and will again, solicit a non-threatened response.
6. So (client) there's a quick example of how we can use cognitive frameworks to improve your creativity and develop ideas to give you a business advantage. We have a range of templates just like this, would you be open to exploring how we could work a little closer with you going forward? (book a time a week or two out from today or simply, "I'll get Mary to phone you when you're in front of your diary and make a time for you to come in. We'll have a chat about your business, I'll come up with some recommendations and we'll take things slowly from there…"

Heald Matrix Follow Up Email

Hi BOB

Thanks for your time on ____ day; it was great to get your thoughts around the methods and ideas you have for growing your business.

As I mentioned, I feel your business could benefit from a combination of improved quality data and a more structured approach to developing business activities that could result in greater profits, less time at work or a reduced level of stress for you and (life partner).

Attached are a few notes that summarises what we spoke of around the Heald Matrix and as agreed, (Mavis) will be in touch in the coming days to arrange a time for me to show you the Business Growth Fundamentals that I promised to share with you.

Until then,

Adam the Accountant.

(attach your branded version of The Heald Matrix)

Using The Heald Matrix Step By Step

1. How to Introduce the Framework (The Segue)

The key to using any framework is a smooth segue into the conversation. You can introduce this in a formal, structured meeting agenda or an informal setting, like grabbing a coffee and drawing it on a napkin to help shift a highly formal client relationship into a more collaborative one.

- Step 1: Listen for cues where the client admits they don't know the answer to your questions or claims they are "too busy" for planning.
- Step 2: Simply ask, "Have you heard of the Heald Matrix?".
- Step 3: When they say no, say, "Let me show you," and write the title "The Heald Matrix" on the page or whiteboard. Writing the title buys you time to collect your thoughts, focuses the client, and creates intrigue.

2. How to Draw and Reveal the Matrix

To prevent the client from becoming overwhelmed, you must reveal the matrix progressively rather than all at once.

- Step 1: Draw your axis indices. Label the vertical axis Innovation/Creativity and the horizontal axis Methodology/Process. Remember to include "high/low" or "+/-" markers to indicate contrast.
- Step 2: Do not draw all four boxes at once to avoid "map shock," which causes the client to stop listening and jump straight into trying to assess all four categories.
- Step 3: Reveal the quadrants one at a time in the following order, discussing the narrative of each before moving to the next:
    - Turtle (Low Innovation, Low Methodology): The "same old thing, same old way" approach. They are slow to react and pull their heads in when things get difficult.
    - Shotgun (High Innovation, Low Methodology): The "shoot and hope" approach. They are creative but lack data and fly by the seat of their pants.
    - Lab-Rat (Low Innovation, High Methodology): Stuck in fear and judgment. Their fixation causes second-guessing and a failure to embrace trial and error.
    - Pioneer (High Innovation, High Methodology): Balances fresh ideas with sound processes for effective testing and deployment.

3. How to Facilitate Client Self-Assessment

Once the matrix is revealed, your goal is to help the client identify their current position without triggering their ego defenses.

- Step 1: Ask, "Where do you think you sit on the matrix?".
- Step 2: Increase their self-relevance by localizing their exact spot. Place your pen on the axis of their chosen box and slowly slide it across, asking them to say "when" to mark their precise horizontal and vertical coordinates.
- Step 3: Ask, "WHAT makes you say that?". If they struggle to provide a reason or meander, write the word "Evidence" on the board. You are looking for objective proof or behaviors to affirm their position, which bypasses their emotive centers and creates disassociation.

4. How to Guide the Client Toward Action

After the client takes ownership of their current state, guide them toward recognizing the need for planning and improvement.

- Step 1: Ask, "Where would you like to be on the matrix in the future?". Almost all clients will aim for the top right of the Pioneer box.
- Step 2: Ask, "IF you took one small baby step towards that, WHAT might that step look like?". Emphasize what it would *look* like, not how it would feel, to force them to imagine a behavioral, actionable change. Using the word "IF" reduces self-judgment and encourages creative, non-threatened responses.
- Step 3: Validate their suggested "baby steps" (e.g., looking at financials once a fortnight).

5. How to Close and Follow Up

Use this exercise as a taste of what it is like to have you facilitate their thinking, pivoting into a broader planning engagement.

- Step 1: Say, "There's a quick example of how we can use cognitive frameworks to improve your creativity... would you be open to exploring how we could work a little closer with you going forward?".
- Step 2: Offer an accessible next step. Do not immediately pitch a $7,000, three-day planning summit; start with a smaller commitment like Skype calls every fortnight or a 45-minute session to bring them along on the journey.
- Step 3: Send a follow-up email summarizing the methods and ideas discussed, attaching a branded version of the Heald Matrix, and confirming the time for your next meeting.

Common Q&A

Q: Can I change the names of the quadrants (Turtle, Shotgun, etc.)?
A: Yes. If terms like "shotgun" don't fit your style, you can absolutely change the names (e.g., "runaround") as long as the new titles gel well with you and support the overarching concept.

Q: Why shouldn't I show the completed graphic to the client all at once?
A: Showing the completed graphic causes "map shock." The client will instantly jump into assessment mode, trying to figure out all four quadrants at once, instead of buying into the story as you build it.

Q: Why is it important to ask "WHAT makes you say that?" instead of "WHY do you think you sit there?"
A: Using the word "WHY" can be inflammatory; it challenges their thinking and causes them to seek an internal defense. Asking "WHAT" prompts the client to seek material, external actions and evidence, which elicits a non-threatened, objective response.

Q: What if the client is being overly humble and places themselves in a worse position than they actually are?
A: You can gently challenge them. If they place themselves at the absolute bottom, you might ask, "You think you're being a bit hard on yourself? You've got a great business, maybe you're further up?" Work with them and test their assumptions to help them cement true ownership of their position.